Ottawa Ankle & Foot Rules — X-ray Decision

acute ankle/midfoot injury · casualty

Ottawa rules

ANKLE X-RAY SERIES IF MALLEOLAR-ZONE PAIN AND ANY OF

Ankle

- A — bone tenderness at the posterior edge or tip of the LATERAL malleolus (distal 6 cm)
- B — bone tenderness at the posterior edge or tip of the MEDIAL malleolus (distal 6 cm)
- Unable to bear weight (4 steps) both immediately after injury and in casualty

FOOT X-RAY SERIES IF MIDFOOT PAIN AND ANY OF

Foot

- C — bone tenderness at the base of the 5th metatarsal
- D — bone tenderness at the navicular
- Unable to bear weight (4 steps) both immediately after injury and in casualty

INTERPRETATION

Any positive X-ray indicated

All negative Fracture very unlikely (sensitivity ≈98–99%) — no X-ray; treat as sprain

DO NOT APPLY IF

- Intoxication, head injury, multiple injuries, reduced sensation in the leg
- Injury >10 days old, or re-assessment of a known injury
- Children: validated from about 5 years; use with caution

SA STG

Minor injuries (incl. sprains) are managed as outpatients — exclude fractures ✚

Sprain: immobilise with a firm bandage and/or temporary splint; analgesia ✚

Children: always consider non-accidental injury ✚

PHC STG & EML Primary Healthcare, 8th ed. 2024 (updated Sept 2026) — pp 21.63, 21.67 · **OTTAWA** Stiell IG et al. Ottawa ankle rules. JAMA 1993;269:1127-32; JAMA 1994;271:827-32